Early Middle Ages (475 – 1000 CE)

As stated earlier in Chapter One, Rome began to face a series of invasions of Germanic tribes from the third century onwards. Roman generals became emperors who were soon assassinated by those seeking the same position and power. This carried on until Constantine's time when he made great religious reforms with the promotion of Christianity. Theodosius I established Christianity again as the new religion in the fourth century. There were continuous raids and invasions from the Goths, Gauls and the Sassanids from the eastern regions. The Huns caused the Goths to migrate eastwards into Roman territory, which triggered fighting between the two parties. When Theodosius I died, the Eastern Roman Empire collapsed. It was later reorganized into what is known as the Byzantine Empire. In 410-455 CE, Rome was besieged by the Germanic king Odovacar. He was successful in eliminating the last emperor of the Western Roman Empire. The great Roman Empire had finally come to an end.

Emperor Justinian reigned from 527 to 565 CE and attempted to take back the territory that once belonged to the Roman Empire including parts of North Africa, Italy and modern-day France. While he seemed to have succeeded, he could not maintain control over these regions. The campaigns were far too expensive and the Byzantine Empire faced incursions from the Lombards who were seeking territory in Italy. As a result, the Empire was unable to hold anything below south of Italy. At the turn of the seventh century CE, the Byzantine Empire held a small strip of North Africa, Parts of Egypt, Anatolia, Thrace, the Balkans and the Levant. Modern-day Germany and France were in the hands of the Franks, while the Visigoths possessed majority of Iberia or modern-day Spain. Britain, known as Britannia at the time, was held by the Angles and Denmark was controlled by the Saxons.

The foundation of medieval Europe was laid between 600 and 800 CE. The Byzantine Empire faced the full strength of the Avars as they made their way towards Thrace. Furthermore, the Sassanids from Persia took the Levant and Anatolia from the empire. The Sassanids were eventually defeated by Heraclius but the damage had already been done. The empire